

Part III — The Substitution

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Father and the Step-Daughter play out the first beats of the shop scene themselves, on the upper platform. The lines they say are the lines they actually said, some years ago, in a back room of a real dressmaker's atelier in Lausanne. The Manager listens from below. The actors watch from below. The Mother trembles on the lower floor. Then the Manager hands the scene to his Leading Lady and Leading Man — they climb up to the platform, taking the place of the Characters, and try the same lines. The Step-Daughter, also up there, laughs at them.

The Players push through it: the hat-offer, the refusal, the mourning reveal, the *I'm frightfully sorry*. They do not break on a laugh. They break on a correction. The Step-Daughter, almost to herself: *He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.* The Father, quietly: *Yes. He said "Oh."* The Leading Lady will not be corrected this precisely by the originals of her part, and she walks. The Leading Man walks after her. The Mother, from the lower floor, breaks in: *It's taking place now. It happens all the time.* She cries out as she did in life, from below up into the rehearsal stage. The Machinist, by accident, drops the curtain on what was supposed to be only a rehearsal effect.

This is the act's first real climax. Pirandello forces the audience to watch the same scene twice and feel both versions as inadequate — the live one too raw, the rehearsed one too polished. The audience leaves the act unsettled and a little ashamed of having been entertained.

Playing the substitution. The doubled scene must never tip into parody — the Leading Man and Leading Lady play it straight and competent; the horror is that it is *good*, and still false. Watch the Characters, not the actors: the Father turning away, the Step-Daughter's laugh hardening into a stare. The hinge is tiny — *He said "Oh."* — and the Mother's *It's taking place now* is the key to the whole production: the wound is not remembered, it is lived again, every night. The accidental curtain falls in earnest — the Machinist means it.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Breezy professional confidence: she has done a thousand scenes harder than this and has no stake in its real wound.

PLAYER 2 [*the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this*]. Of course. It's easy enough. [*To Leading Man.*] Shall you and I try it now?

Eager readiness before anyone has finished speaking — theatrical vanity indifferent to what the original scene actually cost.

PLAYER 1. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [*Exit to make his entrance.*]

Logistics swallow the living moment whole; he is already redistributing bodies before the Characters have drawn breath.

THE MANAGER [*to Leading Lady*]. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

A diva's small act of reclamation — hat back on before surrendering to someone else's story.

PLAYER 2. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. [*Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.*]

Grief becomes a stage direction: bowed head as costume note, anguish rewritten as blocking.

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

Flat, factual, possessive: she will not let a wrong body carry her grief without protest.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

"More effectively" turns trauma into a professional competition — the Leading Lady reaches for victory where the Step-Daughter lived through humiliation.

PLAYER 2 *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

Clapping hands enforce momentum over truth; "learn something" is an insult dressed as pedagogy.

THE MANAGER *[to Step-Daughter]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the Leading Man enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the Actors from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the Step-Daughter and the Father, not being able to recognize themselves in the Leading Lady and the Leading Man, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

A generic greeting with no guilt behind it — without the Father's haunted gaze, the scene is already a different event.

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss...

Two words, and his control collapses: watching his own memory mis-embodied is physically unbearable.

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The Step-Daughter noticing the way the Leading Man enters, bursts out laughing.

Both laughter and protest feel like sabotage; the Manager's fury cannot distinguish between emotional responses and disciplinary problems.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

She weaponises her own body as evidence — her laughter proves the imitation false, contempt becoming theatrical testimony.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating Leading Lady.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

Not concession but reclamation: he reaches for the precise details that constitute his version of events.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

"Rubbish" settles it — the Manager's priority is theatrical shape, not the accuracy of a lived event.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

Comic self-importance about blocking, but it exposes how utterly disconnected he is from the scene's moral weight.

PLAYER 1 *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

"It goes fine" — the moment his authority becomes self-deception; he cannot see what the Characters standing beside him see.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the Actors to begin again.]* Well?

Bare repetition, stripped of any felt content: the hollowness of the imitation is now audible.

PLAYER 1. Good afternoon, Miss.

Three words, perfectly calibrated to be polite and empty — none of the Step-Daughter's compelled, shamed compliance.

PLAYER 2. Good afternoon.

| Recognition and fear delivered as technical beats; beside the Father's original guilt, it reads as theatrical shorthand.

PLAYER 1 *[imitating the gesture of the **Father** when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

| Unable to resist stepping into the scene himself, he exposes his controlling need to shape reality from the inside.

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. *[Acts it himself.]* And you say: "No, sir."

| Technically correct, emotionally inert: a single obedient line that lays bare the gap between compliance and lived submission.

PLAYER 2. No, sir.

| A gallant's knowing gambit; the Father's version held darker knowledge — something that implicated him, not her.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, more than once.

| Choreographed disgust reduced to a traffic signal: the Step-Daughter's involuntary shame becomes a rehearsable head movement.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The **Leading Lady** lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

| Not amusement — horror breaking through as uncontrollable, anguished release at the parody of her worst moment.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

| His oblivious question shows he cannot perceive the emotional reality happening in plain sight beside his rehearsal.

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

| She retreats, calculating that explanation is useless — the Manager will never understand what he has just witnessed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

| Two words of impatience: the scene's machinery must never stop for feeling.

THE MANAGER *[to **Leading Man**]*. Go on!

| Practiced seducer's lightness; the Father's version carried the weight of a man who knows exactly where this leads.

PLAYER 1. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

*The **Leading Man** says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the **Step-Daughter**, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.*

| An urgent whisper betrays his own anxiety — he knows the scene is fragile and is holding it together by willpower alone.

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

| Smooth professional autonomy; the Step-Daughter's original act would have been trembling, deliberate, utterly different.

PLAYER 2 *[recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

| Flattery as a well-oiled key — what the Father felt reaching for the hat was something far more ambivalent.

PLAYER 1 *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

| A scripted beat, not the Step-Daughter's mixture of need and self-disgust.

PLAYER 2 *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

| Light insistence reads as charming theatre; the Father's original pressure came from a more compromised place entirely.

PLAYER 1 *[the smile he has used a thousand times]*. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

An actress hitting her mark: the mourning revelation lands as a practised gesture rather than a girl exposing a wound.

PLAYER 2 *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

Courtesy performed to order; the Father's original apology came out of genuine, complicated shame.

PLAYER 1 *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

*A short, theatrical pause. The **Father** turns his face away. The **Step-Daughter** is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.*

Executed exactly where directed — the precision of the coached catch makes the falseness visible.

PLAYER 2 *[the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

Satisfied note-taking treats the Characters' living memory as raw material to be efficiently processed and filed.

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the **Prompter**]*. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

A tiny, devastating correction: this is the line where theatrical approximation becomes a lie about what actually happened.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself]*. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

To him the words are interchangeable; to her every syllable is scarred into memory — the Manager cannot hear the difference.

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

"His hand stayed on the hat" restores the physical detail the theatre erased; the body's stillness was the scene's real meaning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

Quiet corroboration, not defence: for one brief, painful moment Father and Step-Daughter share the same memory.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

A professional ultimatum that makes explicit the incompatibility: their presence doesn't enrich the scene — it dissolves the fiction.

PLAYER 2 *[breaking character, to **Manager**]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

Authority draining away in three words; he is managing a situation he no longer controls, just keeping the scene alive.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

Sitting down would surrender the only ground she still holds in this theatre — refusal is self-preservation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

Her wounded-diva exit threat is also an unintended truth: her dignity is professional, not personal — she can afford to leave.

PLAYER 2 *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

A visible calculation crosses his face before he speaks; his exit is a decision, not an emotion.

PLAYER 1 *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

"For once and all" betrays exhaustion — he is no longer directing a play, he is refereeing a collision he cannot stop.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to **Step-Daughter**]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

Surprising precisely because it is uncharacteristic: beneath the contempt lives a creature who still wants to be seen.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

He cannot name what is really happening, so he calls it bad manners — scolding entirely about social form.

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

Protection or control, genuine care or image management — the Father's instinct to intercede is ambiguous at its root.

THE FATHER [*endeavouring to intervene*]. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

"Absolutely disgusting" reaches for propriety's language because he has no words for what the Characters actually carry.

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

He reaches for "strange" because he cannot say true; the wrongness is ontological — those actors are simply not them.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

Three repetitions — "Strange? Why strange? Where?" — reveal defensive incomprehension; he feels accused but cannot locate the charge.

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

The play's central wound stated plainly: imitation and identity cannot coincide.

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

"I should hope not" is a logical defence and an unwitting confession that theatre is structurally unable to deliver what they need.

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

The wound, not the theory — he watches them do it well and feels the dispossession: what the actors make is real, and it is no longer his.

THE FATHER. Just so — actors. They act our parts exceedingly well. But what comes out is theirs now, and no longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

Brushing off the Father's protest by citing his own earlier ruling, he retreats into professional habit to mask a growing unease.

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

Capitulation dressed as comprehension — he retreats into repeated compliance, buying time to find another angle of attack.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

He expels the author-figure to restore order, then turns to the characters with an irritation that has nowhere clean to land.

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! [*Turning to the **Actors.***] We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! [*Turning to **Father** and **Step-Daughter.***] Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

Her ominous stillness is predatory; she has stopped resisting and started counting down to the moment that will expose the Father.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

Reducing a degrading negotiation to cue-and-question, he tidies the scene into shorthand that sanitises everything it touches.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you [*Addressing the **Father.***] come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her why she is in mourning.

She replaces the Manager's genteel blocking with the actual words from Madame Pace's room, weaponising verbatim memory against polite fiction.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

His excitement is purely commercial; 'riot in the theatre' means a hit, and he values sensation over the human reality he is staging.

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

Three words strip the debate to its core: she is the custodian of what really happened and will not let fiction overwrite it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

He openly admits truth has a box-office ceiling — a candid confession that the stage is a negotiation between fact and palatability.

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

She delivers a savage précis of the sentimental version he would stage, mocking its falsity and insisting on the childhood detail as the true horror.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off.*

His hands-through-hair betrays real disturbance; for once the theatre professional is not managing the content but genuinely rattled by it.

THE MANAGER *[running his hands through his hair]*. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

Dropping the pretence of performance, she lets stark repetition do the work — the bare fact must stand regardless of theatrical convention.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[no longer playing]*. The truth. The truth.

He concedes her horror privately while denying it publicly; 'it won't go' is commercial self-interest dressed as aesthetic judgement.

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

Two exits folded into one rising refusal: obliged-and-leaving becomes the springboard for naming exactly what he's really after — a tasteful head-drama — against her insistence on her part.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well — I'm much obliged to you. But I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part.*

His lecture on dramatic economy exposes theatre's formal violence against lives that exceed its containers; the softening at the end is entirely strategic.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed, shaking his shoulders]*. Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his *[Indicating the Father.]* and hers *[Indicating the Mother.]*. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. *[softening, sitting on the edge of the table]* You must restrain yourself, my dear — this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

Head lowered, she concedes his point in form while refusing it in substance — the other characters exist for her only as extensions of the Father's guilt.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head lowered, not yielding]*. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

Genuine puzzlement: he has been thinking in roles, not in relational chains, and her logic of inherited ruin is outside his dramaturgical vocabulary.

THE MANAGER *[not understanding]*. What? The others? What do you mean?

She articulates a moral genealogy in which the first violation contaminates everything downstream — a philosophical indictment, not self-pity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

He tries to convert moral accountability into dramatic action, reducing her accusation to a cue in someone else's scene.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

Her rhetorical question dismantles the plan to spare the Father: the child coming out of school is the detail that makes guilt irrefutable, and she is moved by her own memory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? *[She is moved.] [The Mother at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.]*

After the Mother's breakdown she pivots to cold strategy, offering the Manager exactly what he wants while setting terms that will strip away his comfortable version.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[as soon as the Mother becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely]*. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

His eager agreement exposes his instrumentalism — 'as much of it as is possible' — he will harvest the truth only to the depth the production can use.

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

Asking the Mother to leave is her cruelest editorial act: she intends to replay the scene that broke their family without any witness who could stop it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

From passive suffering into active refusal — the only moment she intervenes directly, making audible the pain she normally absorbs in silence.

THE MOTHER *[changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]*. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

His 'only to try it' trivialises a reenactment the Mother experiences as happening now; theatrical bracketing of 'rehearsal' is meaningless to her.

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

Speaking to the children rather than the room, she makes clear her suffering is not performed for the Manager's benefit — she lives in a perpetual present.

THE MOTHER *[to the Child-bundle, not to the room]*. I can't bear it. I can't.

He cannot grasp that for the Mother the past is not past; 'it has happened already' is theatrically logical and humanly irrelevant.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

Refusing the past tense entirely, she insists the torture is present-continuous, the children are anchors to it, and the Step-Daughter's flight is a second abandonment.

THE MOTHER *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech]*. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

He names the asymmetry: pinned to one shameful moment while she is freed by it, he appeals to the Manager for something like proportional justice.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

Converting the Mother's anguish into a dramaturgical pivot — 'nucleus of the whole first act' — he compulsively reduces pain to structure.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the Mother.]*

He reframes punishment as tragic inevitability, using 'passion' to cast himself as a suffering figure rather than an agent of harm.

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

Her physical staging of her own memory — head on breast, eyes closed, vein visible — is simultaneously a wound and a performance; she commands her mother's cry as a director would.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. Cry out as you did then!

The play's most purely maternal moment: she separates them bodily, names the relationship, and finally hurls accusation, her long silence broken into rage.

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them]*. No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

His satisfied retreat toward the footlights — the audience's direction — marks the instant he stops being a collaborator and becomes a spectator.

THE MANAGER *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk]*. Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

His excitement confirms his deepest need: theatrical certification of what really happened is the closest he can get to absolution.

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly]*. Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

His pleasure is aesthetic, not moral; he and the Father share satisfaction in the curtain-line for entirely different reasons.

THE MANAGER *[convinced and pleased]*. Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

At the reiterated cry of The Manager, The Machinist lets the curtain down, leaving The Manager and The Father in front of it before the footlights.

His irritated explanation — curtain as signal, not command — reveals that the theatre's codes are not shared, a gap that will prove fatal later.

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the Father, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.